

also been provided, and the *de facto* RS232 interface to connect to a PC is also present.

In DisplayMate, we noticed a slight deficit in contrast where this projector lost out on about six cards in the *gray scale intensity* check, where the objective is for the projector to display as many gray cards (that range in intensities from less to very intense) as possible on a pitch black background. This test is a very good indication of contrast ratio, and we've learnt to respect the results it throw up, as they're very indicative of performance in movies and games. Geometry was OK, with some aberrations visible in the left corners, which couldn't be removed by calibration. The colours are good, but seem a little dim or muted, and once we calibrate the projector using DisplayMate, we don't interfere with settings, so this continues throughout the other tests as well. Movie and game tests showed more loss of clarity and colours, which was evident in *Crysis* and a lack of contrast visible in the darker, atmospheric scenes in *F.E.A.R.* The rather soft colours, like watching television with your TV set to *soft* picture mode also detracted from the experience.

At a price of Rs 40,000, the MP612c is nice and cheap, and makes an attractive buy. We suggest you stave off the temptation, and take a look at its slighter costlier sibling featured next.

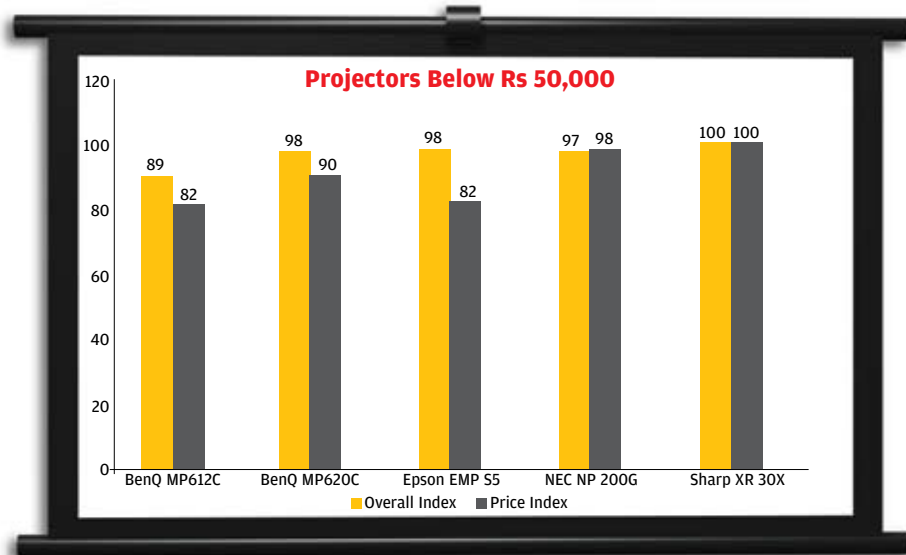
BenQ MP620c

The bigger brother of the MP612c is a slightly better looking projector. They share a remote unit in common and their menus are not too bad. The build quality, and the navy blue finish is as good as its smaller sibling. The part matte part glossy finish is quite well done and adds character to the product.

In the DisplayMate tests, we found a result similar to the MP612c—a



BenQ MP620c



deficit in contrast, which caused it lose out on quite a few grey cards—eight of them in all were indiscernible from the black background. The colour tests proved that BenQ does indeed have softer colours, but the word *dim* seems more apt. We hope BenQ addresses this issue, as it's not really resolvable through calibration and really detracts from any colour related activities like movie watching and gaming. In the text tests, once again some of the text appeared to be a little blurry and the edges of the fonts were once again (*sigh!*) not clearly defined. The MP620c a slightly better projector than its sibling at gaming and *Crysis* was enjoyable, but not as immersive as hardcore gamers would like.

Aimed at the household who wants to upgrade from a large screen TV to a *real* home cinema experience—the MP620c is decent value at Rs 44,000. However, there are better performing options available for nearly the same price point.

Epson EMP-S5

Epson's EMP-S5 is an attractive looking projector finished in (now familiar) glossy white. The front tapers forward, so the device looks rather soft nosed, and the lens is accessible via a slider-type flap mechanism, which when closed, mutes the video and audio signal, in addition to protecting the lens. Epson bundles a small, compact remote unit with this projector with tiny buttons that are surprisingly easy-to-use. On the connectivity front, DVI and Component connects are missing, although USB connectivity is there. The EMP-S5 wireless connectivity, which isn't really significant, as this projector is obviously aimed at home audiences.

In DisplayMate, this projector had minor issues with contrast and also with geometry in the bar resolution tests. In the gray-scale intensity and contrast test, we missed out on eight gray cards, which is a little below our expectations. It performs adequately in the text, animation and photograph tests, no serious complaints here.

We had some great hopes in the movie tests after our last impressions with still images. How wrong we were! The let down is the combination of contrast, brightness and even lack of detail, which leaves a



Epson EMP-S5

somewhat grainy impression noticeable in movies, not something you want when you're shelling out nearly half a lakh for an entertainment system. This graininess also spoils the game test results, and *F.E.A.R.* isn't as fearful as we like it to be. *Crysis* is slightly better mainly because its not as dark a game. At Rs 40,100 the Epson EMP-S5 has a better price to performance ratio than either BenQ projectors, and can be recommended over both of them.

NEC NP200G

This was NEC's only DLP offering in our test. The remote control is small, slim and fits into a recess on the top of the body. Despite its tiny size, the remote works beautifully and the buttons are *soft-touch*—flawless design here. The finish is an off-white satin, which looks smart and feels durable. Connectivity options are restricted to D-Sub, Composite and S-Video, no USB or RJ45 goodness here. This is a projector obviously intended for home users primarily, and the small footprint will be an advantage to this audience. Another factor which is useful for its intended audience, especially those with cramped dwellings, is the nature of its lamp—very short throw. This makes it immensely useful if you have very little space



NEC NP200G

between your projector and your screen and still want to project a relatively larger image than what would be possible using a regular lamp.

The NP200G did decently well in DisplayMate, with good performance in the contrast and colour tests. It also does very well at text and presentations, although the slight softness accompanied by loss of detail upon zooming in on photographs is undesirable, and adversely affected

its score in our image quality test. It's a good movie projector, and suitable for HD movie watching, thanks to spot-on contrast and colours, and good brightness levels. The gaming tests were a little harsher on this projector and we felt both *Crysis* and *F.E.A.R.* could look much better. Basically, the colours didn't seem as vivid as we'd like, and more importantly, the games didn't seem as detailed—some textures looked slightly dull and lifeless. Casual gamers would probably be pleased with the results, but to choose this projector solely for its gaming performance if

you're a hardcore gamer would be a folly.

At Rs 48,000, the NEC NP200G is a very good projector for its price. Although its siblings, the VT800 and VT700 trounce it soundly, they also command double the price. Hardly any similarly priced projectors come close to its performance and this makes the NP200G somewhat of a golden product in this category... Right? The next product featured may change that impression.

Sharp XR-30X

The XR-30X is a lovely looking conglomerate of plastic and metal livered in dark gray and black. A strong profile and dark good looks coupled with the fact that this projector is built like a tank. Sharp has done an excellent job of the remote control unit.

The menu system, however, is not intuitive and the background colour used for the menu is



Sharp XR-30X

very distracting from the colour of the text. Perhaps if the guys at Sharp read this, a revision may sort out this issue which is admittedly minor. Connectivity is good with RJ45 making an appearance along with both VGA and DVI connects.

On to DisplayMate's suite, the XR-30X's contrast is pretty good, as is its ability to work with colours. With great performance in the resolution and geometry tests, it was understandable that text quality would be good, but the XR-30X was absolutely excellent! Sharp, clear and precise text with no visible aliasing or anomalies, the clarity was amazing. The quality of photographs was also very good—as good as we've seen from many of the sub